

Association for Autism and Neurodiversity (AANE)

For Executive Director Brenda Dater, who had first encountered the Association for Autism and Neurodiversity (also known as AANE) as the parent of an autistic child, the Boston-based nonprofit was much more than a job, it was a labor of love. When Dater and her family relocated to Boston in the early 2000s, they intentionally moved close to AANE so that she could volunteer and get involved in programs and support groups. She later applied for a staff job, and then moved up through the ranks. “It’s been 18 years, and I’ve stayed in four different roles. AANE is unique in the sense that it’s the first place I found that really was hopeful about the future [for autistic adults]. This place was like, ‘We understand the challenges and the strengths of people who are autistic. We want to build community and decrease isolation.’”

Under Dater’s leadership, by 2023, AANE was serving approximately 14,000 autistic adults annually through a variety of services. Their educational programs, social and support groups, and individualized coaching are designed with the input of AANE’s autistic staff and community members. In addition, AANE partnered with researchers and advocated for policies to promote the well-being and rights of neurodiverse individuals.

At the same time, demand for AANE’s programs was growing faster than the organization’s capacity to provide services. “Thousands more people were coming,” Dater said, and AANE added program staff to meet the demands. But revenue could not keep up.

At the close of 2023, AANE had accumulated an operating deficit of nearly \$350,000, meaning that funding was less than the amount needed to pay expenses. The organization’s financial reserves were available to fill this gap, but Dater knew the organization couldn’t continue like this. “The [nonprofit] board isn’t going to approve a deficit budget,” Dater said. Even though AANE

wasn't a for-profit business, it needed enough funds to operate. Dater would have to find a way to break-even and build back cash reserves, or risk closing, which had happened to two similar local nonprofits.

AANE's Mission and Services

Founded in 1996 as the Asperger's Association of New England, AANE grew to become a key resource provider and advocate for the neurodiverse community. According to their mission, "AANE helps Autistic and similarly Neurodivergent people build meaningful, connected lives. We provide individuals, families, and professionals with education, community, and support in an inclusive atmosphere of validation and respect" (AANE n.d.).

The organization works to create a more inclusive society where neurodiverse individuals can thrive. According to Dater, autistic individuals are more likely than the general population to experience depression, and difficulty with social interactions can prevent autistic adults from engaging in social activities. They are also more likely to experience trauma, such as bullying or abuse, and post-traumatic stress disorder.

AANE's services are diverse and cater to a variety of clients in the neurodiverse community with different needs. They include:

- **Educational Programs:** AANE provides workshops, seminars, and training sessions for autistic individuals, parents/caregivers, educators, and healthcare professionals. These programs aim to improve understanding of neurodiversity and equip participants with strategies to effectively support neurodiverse individuals.
- **Support Groups:** AANE runs support and social groups for individuals with autism and their families. These groups offer a safe space for sharing experiences, decreasing isolation, gaining emotional support, and accessing resources.
- **Individualized Services:** AANE offers information and resource consultations and coaching for parents. AANE also developed LifeMAP, which works one-to-one with over 3,000 autistic teens, young adults,

and adults to help them improve their quality of life, increase independence, and progress toward reaching their full potential.

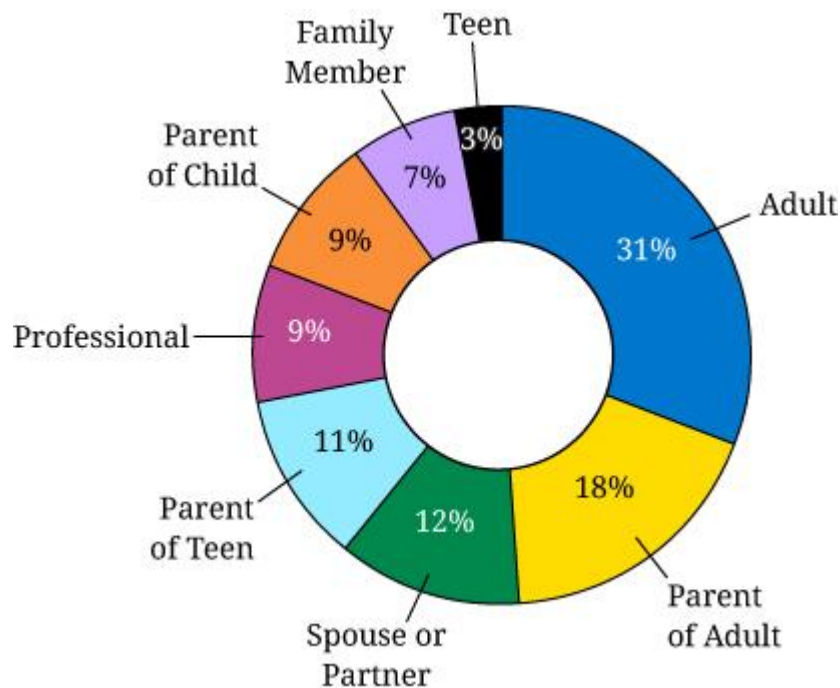


Figure 1. Clients receiving services from AANE in 2023

According to their 2023 *Annual Report*, AANE's programs served 14,117 clients that year, including teens, family members, and professionals (Figure 1). This was a 15% increase over 2022.

Financial Structure

As a nonprofit, AANE relies on two main revenue sources to finance its operations:

1. **Grants and Contributions:** AANE receives grants from government bodies, private foundations, and corporate sponsors. These grants are typically earmarked for specific programs or initiatives, such as autistic women's support groups, which means they cannot be spent on general organizational expenses or other programs. Individual contributions also form a significant part of AANE's revenue. The

organization runs various fundraising campaigns throughout the year to solicit donations from the public.

2. **Program Service Fees:** These fees are revenue earned from coaching and training; groups; fees from conferences, workshops, and seminars; and membership revenue from individuals and organizations.

As a service provider, AANE's primary operating expenses are employee costs. Approximately 80% of AANE's total expenses go to annual salaries and wages. Other expenses include administration and fundraising costs. AANE's 2023 financial data is shown in Table 1.

Cash Flow Challenges

Table 1 AANE 2023 Financial Statement of Income and Expense

Revenue		
Program Service Fees	\$3,545,223	
Contributions & Grants*	\$1,856,979	
Other	\$104,537	
TOTAL		\$5,506,739
Expenses		
Cost of Services	\$4,646,314	
Administrative	\$785,948	
Fundraising	\$422,244	
TOTAL		(\$5,854,506)
OPERATING INCOME		(\$347,767)

*Nonprofits report contributions and grants as revenue

Source: AANE Annual Report, 2023

In addition to the 2023 deficit, AANE faced ongoing cash flow challenges that threatened its financial stability and its ability to meet demand for its services. AANE typically raised significant funding during its seasonal campaigns, including annual appeal notecards (sent before Thanksgiving and usually returned after New Year's), which share an individual's story of how they were impacted by AANE and request a donation. However, this was not a steady source of funding during the year.

Similarly, grants from the government, foundations, and other businesses often arrived at the end of the year or during a specific part of the granting organization's financial year. Like donations and contributions, grants do not provide a steady, year-round source of funding.

Meanwhile, AANE faced high, relatively fixed operating costs that had to be paid monthly or even more frequently. Running educational programs, coaching, and support groups required paying staff salaries, costs for program materials, venue rentals, and other operational expenses. These high costs strained AANE's cash flow, especially during periods of low revenue and contributions.

To manage cash flow gaps, AANE occasionally relied on a bank line of credit—an open-ended loan that operates similar to a consumer's credit card. While these financial tools provided temporary relief, they also added to the organization's debts and created an additional interest expense. Repaying these debts further strained cash flow and limited AANE's ability to invest in growth.

Addressing the Gap

Dater knew that without money, she wouldn't be able to focus on AANE's critical mission, so in late 2023 and early 2024 she took several steps to address the deficit. She, her staff, and outside advisors dug deep into the financials of every individual program to analyze each cost tied to a program, benefits to clients, and program fees. "Some will have a deficit but are critical," Dater said. Critical programs are ones where AANE has deep expertise and a unique approach, and where the program has a high impact on clients.

AANE shut down several programs that Dater described as "nice to haves" (where clients could find similar services elsewhere), paused two programs, and reduced the geographic scope of service for other programs. They began charging a service fee of \$10 for some programs that had been free, and they laid off several staff members. Dater also increased AANE's line of credit at

the bank, while still never borrowing more than they could pay back within 2–5 business days. As a result, AANE solved the deficit—and served 2,000 fewer people in 2024.

Looking to the future, Dater knew she had to plan for sustainable growth and manage cash flow if she was going to meet demand for AANE's services. One option was to continue to increase service fees, which automatically bring in more income when programs grow. But AANE would risk losing clients—a serious drawback—and they'd get pushback from community members who were used to receiving services for free. Another option would be to seek more donations from big funders, like foundations and corporations that embrace mission-driven giving. A drawback to this tactic is that seeking funders takes time and money for staff members, and there's no guarantee that a funder will make more than a one-time donation.

Dater had to decide which option would ensure a more stable financial future for AANE: increased service fees or a greater focus on fundraising?

Brenda Dater was interviewed in 2024 by a College Board case author for this case study.

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References

AANE. 2023 Annual Report. <https://aane.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/10/2023-Annual-Report.pdf>.

AANE. n.d. "About AANE." Accessed March 8, 2025. <https://aane.org/about-us/about-aane-5/>.

1. What organization is featured in this case? What service(s) does the organization provide?
 2. Who is named in the case, and what is/are their role(s)? Describe other stakeholders (individuals and groups) with an interest in the organization.
 3. Describe an opportunity and/or challenge facing the business in this case.
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1. Describe the clients who are most likely to receive services from AANE, based on Figure 1.
 2. Explain how one of AANE's programs (educational programs, social and support groups, individualized coaching), which are "designed with the input of AANE's autistic staff and community members", aligns with the organization's stated mission.
 3. Explain how AANE's mission and its goal of viability came into conflict in 2023.